Léa worried Nadiya was too weak; her face had gone pale, which was the opposite of Maria's bright red cheeks when she'd been in labor. A flutter of dread ran through Léa as she sensed something was wrong. But then, the baby's crown emerged, just like with Maria, and for a moment, relief washed over her. She glanced up at Nadiya, whose lifeless pallor filled her with new fear.

"I can see the baby's head. One more push and your child will soon be in your arms."

Nadiya's toes dug into the mattress as she pushed. The baby slid out fast, and Léa caught the tiny body, wrapping the infant in a cloth.

"Bravo, Nadiya," Rose said. "It's a girl. Now, you can sing to your daughter."

Nadiya smiled and closed her eyes, humming lightly.

"Rose, come hold her while I deal with the placenta."

Rose guided Nadiya back gently down to the bed before joining her sister. As she bent over to take the baby from Léa's arms, *clink*—something slipped from her pocket, rolling across the floor to Léa's feet. It was a ring. And even from here, she could see the glint of a precious stone.

"Is that yours? Where did you get it?" Léa asked.

Rose didn't answer as she bent down, took it and tucked it back inside her pocket.

"I found it," she said.

"It's got diamonds on it. Where would you find a ring like that?" Léa asked, carefully handing the baby to her, the umbilical cord still attached.

"In the canteen," Rose said.

Léa frowned. She would ask her more about the ring later. Now, she needed to focus on Nadiya. *Get the placenta out to cut the cord.* That's what she'd seen Josef do. She massaged Nadiya's belly and after a few minutes, the placenta slipped out, and along with it, a rush of blood.

"I think Nadiya's fainted," Rose said. "Look how pale she is."

The blood kept flowing, gushing, and pooling around Léa's feet. She didn't know what to do. Josef had once told her that undernourished mothers in labor risked having a weak uterus that could fail to contract after birth. Is that why Nadiya was bleeding so much? If the uterus didn't contract, she would hemorrhage. Léa's throat went dry. She didn't know how to save her. The room went still and quiet.